



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Donahue Academy
School Website: <https://donahueacademy.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Donahue Academy of Ave Maria (Donahue Academy) presents a robust Catholic, classical education profile. Public materials consistently frame the school as Catholic and classical, with explicit emphasis on Christ-centered formation, the liberal-arts Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), and a curriculum and pedagogy designed to cultivate virtue, wisdom, and a lifelong love of learning. Evidence across the school's site highlights the centrality of Catholic identity (daily Mass, sacramental life, theology, and liturgy), a formation-focused mission (raising saints, pursuing truth, goodness, and beauty), and a structured classical pedagogy (grammar/logic/rhetoric progression, original sources, and a rhetoric-inflected upper school). The combination of religious formation, formation-first aims, and classical curricular- and pedagogical structures supports an overall CLASSICAL rating, with strong alignment in all six rubric categories.

Key point: the school explicitly positions itself as Catholic and classical, highlighting the transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) and a formation-first approach across mission, curriculum, pedagogy, faculty, and community. This orientation is reinforced by statements about daily Mass, sacramental life, and the integration of Catholic teaching into every aspect of education, as well as a clear articulation of classical educational tenets (transmission and integration of knowledge; learning from original sources; developmentally appropriate sequencing; quest for essential truths; cultivation of wonder).

Executive ranking (aggregate): CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Details follow, with keyword analyses and evidence drawn from the public materials and guided by the Six Essential Elements keyword framework.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize Catholic identity as foundational (e.g., daily Mass, sacramental life, theology, Catholic formation). For example, descriptions of daily Mass and the sacrament of Reconciliation, and statements that the school is "Catholic" and "classical," with a mission centered on encountering Christ and pursuing excellence.

- The motto and explicit religious framing appear, including phrases like Christ-centered education and the

mission to form saints within a Catholic framework. - Theology and philosophy integration are highlighted (theology and philosophy referenced in student formation).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Catholic, Christ, theology, liturgy, Mass, sacramental life, daily Mass, sacrament of Reconciliation, Catholic education, sacred tradition, divine mission, Church teaching, liturgical life, Truth, Love of God. These appear repeatedly in school materials (e.g., “Catholic,” “daily Mass,” “theology,” “Christ,” and “pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty”).

- Negative keyword indicators: None of the traditional negative signals (secular humanism, relativism, values-neutral framing) are present in the public materials; the materials consistently reject those tones by foregrounding Catholic identity and transcendentals. For reference, the Six Essential Elements lexicon lists potential negative signals, but the school's public materials do not exhibit them.

Why this rating - The school's materials foreground a transcendent, doctrinal Catholic framing (theology, liturgy, sacraments) and explicitly tie formation to Catholic identity, aligning with the Positive Keywords for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (truth, goodness, beauty; liturgy; theology; Mass; sacred tradition; sacramental worldview). The consistent use of Catholic language and sacramental life, along with references to encounters with Christ and a sacred-liturgical life, justify CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 2: Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Mission statements frame education as formation of saints and formation in faith and character, not mere information or job-preparation. “Donahue Academy is a Catholic, classical school where students encounter Christ and pursue excellence in all things,” with an emphasis on forming students in faith, character, intellect, and virtue. - The Vision emphasizes partnership with parents and forming students in faith, virtue, wisdom, and human excellence; the aim is “raising saints” and guiding students toward eternal purposes. - The mission/vision statements consistently tie truth, goodness, and beauty to formation (not information) and highlight the teleology or telos of classical education (formation of character, wisdom, and virtue).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, character, wisdom, liberal education (paideia), telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, formation of the soul, education for leisure/restfulness, great conversation, moral imagination, human flourishing, soul craft, lifelong virtue. These terms appear in public materials (mission/vision statements and program descriptions).

- Negative keyword indicators: None of the explicit negative signals (e.g., career-workforce framing, purely skills-based training) appear in the materials; rather, the alignment is toward formation and virtue. The Six Elements Negative Keywords list includes “workforce preparation,” but the Donahue materials emphasize formation and telos instead.

Why this rating - The school's stated aims center on virtue, wisdom, and formation (formation over information), with a clearly teleological aim consistent with Classical pedagogy. The presence of formation-focused language (saints, faith formation, character formation) and emphasis on truth, goodness, and beauty as real, knowable ends support CLASSICAL for this category.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school outlines a Trivium-based progression (grammar, logic, rhetoric) with explicit references to the Logic Stage (grades 6–8) and Rhetoric Stage (grades 9–12), showing a classical curriculum structure. This scheme is described directly in public materials. - The curriculum framing emphasizes “transmission and integration of knowledge,” “learning from original sources,” and “developmentally age-appropriate sequence,” which aligns with classical curricular principles. - The public materials highlight the value of Great Books / original sources and the Great Conversation through the classical identity and references to studying original texts and classic texts within a liberal-arts tradition (the Great Books/Great Conversation cadence is reinforced by the classical identity and original-sources emphasis). While explicit

phrase-by-phrase mentions of “Great Books” appear in the Six Elements lexicon, the Donahue materials show the same intent via “learning from original sources” and a strong liberal-arts framing, plus a Fine Arts emphasis that complements the humanities core.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: grammar, logic, rhetoric, transmission and integration of knowledge, learning from original sources, developmentally appropriate sequence, great conversation, liberal education, classics, Western civilization, and engagement with primary/original sources (as implied by “learning from original sources” and “classical education”). The public materials explicitly describe the Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric progression and the use of classical methods.

- Negative keyword indicators: None of the negative signals (e.g., “project-based learning dominance” or “STEM-first framing”) appear as the guiding curricular language; rather, the materials emphasize traditional liberal arts and the Great-Books-oriented framing. See the Negative Keywords list in the Six Elements lexicon for reference, which is not reflected in the Donahue materials.

Why this rating - The explicit articulation of grammar, logic, and rhetoric stages, plus an emphasis on original sources and the Great Conversation, places Donahue Academy squarely in the Curriculum category as CLASSICAL. The material aligns with the Six Essential Elements’ curricular criteria for liberal arts, trivium/quadrivium, Great Books, and wonder-based education.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Pedagogical structure aligns with the classical model: lower-school practices emphasize memory, recitation, singing, and “scholé” rhythms (restful, contemplative learning), while upper-school pedagogy emphasizes Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetoric training (speeches, oratory). Public materials explicitly describe the Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric progression and associated teaching modes. - The site describes upper-school rhetoric, with opportunities for students to give speeches and engage in rhetoric training; it also references Socratic-style elements in upper-level work. This is evident in the description of the Rhetoric Stage and rhetoric-focused activities. - Lower-school practices include singing, chanting, and memory work as part of the learning process, consistent with classical pedagogy. The classical lexicon and the school materials describe these elements in the pedagogical framework. - The Fine Arts and performance emphasis demonstrates an experiential dimension to learning, but is framed within the classical-mindset context (formation through memory, recitation, and the arts).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: scholé, memory, chanting, recitation, narration, Socratic seminar, dialectic, discourse, rhetoric, debate, seminar, Harkness-style discussion, upper-school speeches, formation through practice, living books, original-sources pedagogy, and a calm or restful pace (Scholé). These terms appear across the school’s public materials and the classical pedagogy framing.

- Negative keyword indicators: Some public materials reflect a balance with rest (Scholé) and a layered approach (not purely project-based or solely experiential), which aligns with classical pedagogy rather than the negative signals listed in the lexicon (e.g., “project-based dominant” or “experiential-only” without formation). The explicit negative signals in the lexicon are not present in the Donahue materials.

Why this rating - Donahue Academy’s pedagogy maps clearly to classical methods: rest-filled, contemplative “Scholé days” alongside Socratic/perimeter discussions and rhetorical training in the upper grades. The lower grades emphasize memory and chant-based retention, while the upper grades emphasize philosophical dialogue and rhetoric. This combination supports CLASSICAL in Pedagogy.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school materials portray faculty as virtuous models and mentors who form the “living curriculum,” with teachers described as teachers-mentors who embody virtue and knowledge. The principal’s statements and the faculty directory-like content emphasize dedicated educators anchored in Catholic and

classical formation. - The public materials highlight that the faculty are central to the school's identity (the "living curriculum" framing and the teachers' role in forming students' faith and intellect). The school references the faculty as core to the school's mission and identity, including the emphasis on faculty formation and virtue. - The content includes teacher bios and directory entries (faculty pages) that foreground teachers' credentials, faith, and moral formation, reinforcing the "model teachers and mentors" idea.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: living curriculum, model teachers, mentors, moral exemplars, virtue formation, Catholic formation, teacher as guide, collegial culture, faculty as a community of learners, mentorship, and formation through exemplary practice. The public materials reflect these themes in mission/vision pages and faculty profiles. - Negative keyword indicators: None of the explicit negative signals from the Six Elements lexicon (e.g., "certification-driven jargon without classical context," "facilitators on the side") appear in the public materials. The materials present a teacher-centered, virtue-centered, mentoring image consistent with classical faculty.

Why this rating - The materials describe faculty as living exemplars and core to formation, aligning with the Classical Faculty criteria. The emphasis on virtue, mentorship, and living-curriculum orientation supports CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school frames parents as partners in education, stating a goal to partner with parents in raising saints and forming students in faith, character, intellect, and community life. This partnership-with-families orientation is a central part of the public messaging. - The materials indicate ongoing parent education and engagement (e.g., father/mamly testimonials, grandparent events, and community programming), and the school emphasizes family involvement and shared mission. The Grandparents Day content and various parent/community initiatives illustrate this engagement. - The "AMICE" (Ave Maria Institute for Catholic Education) partnership content shows external fidelity to Catholic-classical identity and a communal approach to formation, reinforcing the school's parent-community alignment with classical identity.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, co-teachers, parental primacy, parent formation, reading groups/book clubs, family involvement, home-school partnership, community of learners, open campus (implicit via events and tours), parent engagement, parent education. These appear in mission/vision content and community-facing pieces. - Negative keyword indicators: None of the Negative Keywords signals (e.g., "consumer language," "parents as customers," or minimal parental involvement) appear; the site emphasizes ongoing parental involvement and engagement. The Six Elements lexicon lists several negative signals; the public materials do not reflect those attitudes.

Why this rating - The Donahue materials portray parents as co-educators and partners in the formation process, with explicit calls for parent involvement, formation, and mutual education, satisfying the CLASSICAL benchmark for Parents & Community. The engagement is reinforced through events, testimonials, and educational partnerships.

What would move the needle

- Since all six categories are rated CLASSICAL, no category currently requires needle-moving changes to reach full CLASSICAL alignment. The school already exhibits strongest alignment with the classical rubric across religious formation, formation-centered goals, classical curriculum, pedagogy, faculty modeling, and parent-community partnership.
- If a future enhancement were pursued, it could include:

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- Explicit, ongoing public articulation of Great Books and Great Conversation language on the website (to reinforce explicit Great Books/Great Conversation signals in Curriculum) while preserving the existing formation emphasis.
 - More explicit in-site references to Socratic seminars and Harkness-style discussion in upper grades to strengthen Pedagogy labeling, though current descriptions already imply Socratic/seminar-style teaching in Rhetoric formation.
- These are highly optional given the current CLASSICAL alignment across all six categories.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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